

Statement of Work (SOW)

Title: Studies of Foodborne Pathogens in Small Specialty Farms

1. Purpose

The purpose of this contract is to acquire follow on scientific services for PO# 75F40121C00181, that will end on 9/29/2026, to support the FDA's Office of Applied Microbiology and Technology (OAMT) in evaluating the sources and transmission routes of human pathogens in agricultural environments where fresh produce is grown, harvested, packed, and held for human consumption. The resulting data will inform food safety practices aimed at minimizing contamination risks on small specialty farms in the Northeast.

2. Background

The Office of Applied Microbiology and Technology (OAMT) provide scientific leadership for FDA's Human Foods Program (HFP) in the areas of microbiology, risk mitigation, and method development. OAMT collaborates with academic institutions and federal stakeholders through the Produce Safety Research Consortium to generate real-world data on environmental factors affecting the safety of fresh produce.

This project will support targeted environmental sampling and laboratory analysis conducted by the Northeast Center to Advance Food Safety (NECAFS), leveraging its cross-regional network of farmers, researchers, and cooperative extension personnel.

The data will enable the FDA's Human Food Program to conduct follow-on research in controlled environments to optimize human pathogen detection methods and better understand preventive strategies for limiting or preventing contamination of fresh produce.

3. Objectives

- Conduct environmental sampling at participating farms
- Perform laboratory analysis on collected samples
- Capture relevant metadata for each sample
- Convey sample results to participating farms
- Coordinate with FDA and academic researchers
- Develop a final report and submit manuscripts to peer-reviewed journals

4. Scope

The contractor shall provide personnel, equipment, coordination, and expertise to:

- Collect soil, compost, water, and swab samples from fresh produce farms
- Analyze samples using FDA Bacteriological Analytical Manual (BAM) methods
- Coordinate research with academic collaborators and OAMT personnel
- Communicate findings to farmers and stakeholders in the Northeast region

NECAFS' role as a USDA/FDA-funded regional food safety center ensures strong relationships with covered farms and cooperative extension networks. If subcontracting is required, indirect costs for any subcontractor may not exceed NECAFS's 25.7% rate.

5. Tasks and Deliverables

Task 1: Kick-Off Meeting

Participate in a virtual kickoff meeting within 7 days of contract award to confirm the project scope, research questions, and deliverable expectations.

Task 2: Research Plan

Develop and submit a Research Plan within 30 days of award. The plan must outline sampling types and methods, analysis approach, timelines, and deliverables.

Task 3: Execute Research Plan

3.1 Sampling: Collect environmental samples (soil, manure, compost, water, swabs) per FDA BAM methods.

3.2 Metadata: Record relevant metadata for each sample collected.

3.3 Laboratory Analysis: Perform analysis on samples and ship blinded samples to FDA when required.

3.4 Reporting to Farmers: Communicate sampling results to participating farms.

3.5 Data Analysis: Analyze study results and summarize key findings.

Task 4: Stakeholder Meetings

Participate in ad hoc virtual coordination meetings and attend one in-person annual meeting hosted by FDA at OAMT in Laurel, MD.

Task 5: Progress Reporting

Submit at least quarterly progress reports summarizing activities, issues, results, and preliminary findings.

Task 6: Final Report and Publications

Submit a final report summarizing the full year of work. Prepare and submit 1–2 peer-reviewed publications with optional FDA co-authorship.

6. Deliverables Summary

Task	Deliverable	Format	Due Date	Recipient
1	Kickoff Meeting Summary	Contractor format	Within 7 days of award	COR
2	Research Plan	Contractor format	Within 30 days of award	COR
3	Sample Collection & Lab Results	Contractor format	3–5 months after award	COR
4	Stakeholder Meeting Notes	Contractor format	Ongoing/ad hoc	COR
5	Quarterly Progress Reports	Contractor format	Quarterly	COR
6	Final Report & Journal Manuscripts	Contractor format	Within 30 days of project end	COR

7. Period of Performance

Base Year: 9/30/2026 – 9/29/2027

OY1: 9/30/27-9/29/28

OY2: 9/30/28-9/29/29

OY3: 9/30/29-9/29/30

OY4: 9/30/30-9/29/31

8. Travel

Travel shall be limited to essential research activities or FDA-requested meetings and must be approved in advance. Annual travel costs are capped at \$2,500, reimbursed per the Federal Travel Regulation.

9. Place of Performance

University of Vermont Extension – NECAFS, Bennington, VT

Participating farms in the Northeast

Annual meeting held at FDA OAMT, 8301 Muirkirk Road, Laurel, MD

10. Government Furnished Property

No government-furnished property, materials, or equipment will be provided under this contract.

11. Points of Contact

FDA Contracting Officer's Representative (COR):

Kristen McLaughlin – kristen.mclaughlin@fda.hhs.gov

FDA Technical Contact:

Stephen Hughes – stephen.hughes@fda.hhs.gov

Contractor Program Lead:

Elizabeth Newbold – elizabeth.newbold@uvm.edu

UVM Extension – NECAFS, Bennington, VT

12. Federal Holidays and Closures

No services are required on federal holidays or during officially declared government closures.